

CHECKLIST

The Nap Salvage Same-Day Checklist

Use this checklist on the day of a skipped nap and you will land bedtime without a two-hour battle, even on an overtired baby. Parents who follow this stop a single skipped nap from unravelling the entire week — starting today.

HOW TO USE THIS

This is a single-page same-day action checklist you pull out the moment your baby skips a nap — before the overtiredness spiral takes hold. Work through the steps in order, starting from whichever point in the day the nap was missed. You are not reading to learn; you are following a decision path in real time so you can get ahead of a bad bedtime instead of improvising through one.

☐ **STEP 1 — Note the exact time the skipped nap was supposed to start**

Write it down or type it into your phone right now: e.g. '10:30am nap — skipped.' This is your anchor point for every timing calculation that follows. Without a fixed reference you will be guessing, and guessing is what gets you into trouble at 7pm.

☐ **STEP 2 — Accept the nap is gone and do not attempt a rescue nap after 30 minutes of trying**

If your baby has been awake for more than 30 minutes past the nap start time and is not asleep, close the attempt. A late rescue nap that lands after its window will push bedtime later and compound the overtiredness — it does not cancel it.

☐ **STEP 3 — Compress the next wake window by 20–30 minutes**

If your baby's normal wake window is 2.5 hours, bring the next nap or bedtime forward to 2 hours (or 2h 15min) instead. An overtired baby cannot self-regulate past her normal window — you are meeting her where she actually is, not where the schedule says she should be.

☐ **STEP 4 — Calculate your new 'pull-forward bedtime' right now**

Take your usual bedtime (e.g. 7:00pm) and subtract 30–45 minutes for a fully skipped nap (e.g. target 6:15–6:30pm). Write it here: TARGET BEDTIME TODAY = _____. Pin this to your fridge or lock screen so your partner sees it too and you both commit before the witching hour hits.

☐ **STEP 5 — Start your wind-down routine 20 minutes before the pull-forward bedtime**

If your target bedtime is 6:20pm, wind-down starts at 6:00pm — not 6:35pm when she's already past it. Wind-down for an overtired baby means: lights dimmed, no screens, no high-stimulation play, no visitors or loud voices. A calm environment now is doing active work.

☐ **STEP 6 — Run a shorter, quieter feed than usual**

Offer a feed as part of the wind-down, but keep it calm and brief — aim for 5–8 minutes, not a full comfort feed. You want the edge taken off hunger without tipping her into a full feed-to-sleep association. If she falls asleep on the breast or bottle, gently rouse her — just enough that her eyes half-open — before placing her in the cot.

☐ **STEP 7 — Use the Overtired Entry, not your standard settle**

On a normal night you might put her down drowsy and step back. Tonight she is wired-and-tired, not just tired — her cortisol is elevated and she will startle more easily. Place her in the cot, keep one hand firmly on her chest for 60 full seconds before you move it, and stay within her eyeline. Do not rush the hand removal.

☐ **STEP 8 — Expect and plan for one protest cycle — it is not a sign the plan is failing**

An overtired baby will often settle for 2–3 minutes, then spike into a short protest cry as the cortisol peaks. This is neurological, not a signal that she needs rescuing. Give it 2 minutes before you re-enter. Write this on a Post-it and stick it to the monitor: '2 minutes. This is normal. She is not in danger.'

☐ **STEP 9 — Re-enter with a reset settle, not a full restart**

If she escalates past 2 minutes, go in and use a brief physical reset: hand on chest, shush at a consistent rhythm (louder than you think — match her volume, then slowly drop yours), and do not pick up unless she is at full distress. The goal is regulated, not asleep-in-arms. Exit again once she drops below active crying.

☐ **STEP 10 — Cap your re-entries at three before escalating to a full hold**

If you have done three re-entry resets and she is still escalating — not just grizzling, but genuinely distressed — pick her up, hold her upright (not rocking), wait for the full-body tension to release, then put her back down. This is a regulated reset, not a surrender. One hold does not undo the work.

☐ **STEP 11 — Log the actual sleep time and total overnight wake count**

When she finally goes down, note the time: 'Asleep at ____.' Tomorrow morning, record how many times she woke. This data point tells you whether the compressed bedtime worked and whether you need to adjust tomorrow's schedule — you are not just surviving tonight, you are building evidence.

☐ **STEP 12 — Protect tomorrow's first nap window above everything else**

After a skipped-nap day, the first nap the next morning is your reset lever. Offer it at the lower end of her wake window (e.g. 1h 45min after wake-up, not 2h 30min) and run the full wind-down, even for a nap. One protected nap tomorrow morning breaks the cycle and stops a single bad day becoming a bad week.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Now Anchor This to Your Settling Sequence Reset

This checklist handles the same-day damage control. The reason it works is that it's built on the same core principles behind the Settling Sequence Reset you're learning inside Sleep Reset for New Parents — specifically the wake window calibration and the regulated re-entry protocol from Module 2. Head back into the programme now and run through the Settling Sequence Reset walkthrough for overtired babies so that tonight's re-entry steps feel familiar in your hands, not just on paper. The more you've rehearsed the sequence before 6pm, the less your body will override you when the crying starts.

[Go to Module 2: The Settling Sequence Reset](#)